SESSION 4

Learning to Synthesize

Design Thinking for MBAs (Hybrid Section)

Thursday, March 26, 2026 | 6:30 PM | Online (Zoom) | Faculty: Patrick Ray

Find the Duct Tape

You've been in the field for two weeks. What duct tape did you find? What workarounds are people using in the problem spaces you investigated?

Two people share. Keep it quick.

8 minutes

Tonight you learn how to turn raw data into **insight**.

Tonight's Plan

Before you touch your own data, we're going to practice **synthesis** together on a shared dataset.

First Half

Guided synthesis on a real design project's field data.

Second Half

Apply the same method to your own research, then stress test your causal loop maps.

Design Ability Tonight

Synthesize Information

Move from **raw data** to **patterns** to **insight**. The hardest design ability because your brain wants to skip steps.

Synthesis is finding the thing the data is telling you that **you didn't already believe**.

The Exercise

45 field observations. 5 observers. One problem space.

What is this data telling us?

The Design Brief

"Voting access in the LGBT community"

5 observers went to spaces across Houston's Montrose neighborhood.

- **A**: Montrose bar, weeknight
- **B**: LGBT resource center
- **C**: Coffee shop / bookstore
- **D**: Different bar, weekend
- **E**: Community support group

> This data comes from real community spaces. If the content resonates personally, that's valid. We're focused on synthesis as a method.

Silent Reading

Read all 45 observations. I've dropped a PDF in the chat. Open it and read.

Notice what you notice. Don't try to organize yet. Just read.

7 minutes | Silent

When time is up: **drop in the chat** the number of one observation that surprised you, and one word for why.

Guided Synthesis

Four moves.

Move 1: Observations vs. Interpretations

Observation

What you saw, heard, counted.

"The younger person kept looking around the room while writing."

Interpretation

What you think it means.

"...like she was blocking the view from the rest of the room."

Interpretations are hypotheses, not facts.

Move 2: Cluster

Group observations that seem related. Narrate your reasoning.

> Not "these are all about voting." **Why** do they go together?
>
> "I'm putting 1, 10, 20, and 33 together. They all vote, none have access problems. But they all say something else is wrong."

When an observation could go in two clusters, that tension is telling you something.

Move 3: Name the Patterns

Vague

- "Barriers to voting"
- "Community stuff"
- "Trust issues"

Precise

- "People who can access polls but experience voting as hostile or pointless"
- "Community infrastructure that replaces institutional services"
- "Rational withdrawal from systems perceived as unsafe"

If the name doesn't surprise you, it's a category, not an insight.

"Access to what, though?"

Bartender, Observation #44

Move 4: Break the Frame

The brief said **"Voting access in the LGBT community."**

Based on this data, is voting access actually the problem?

- How many people here have an actual **access** problem?
- What do the non-voters say about **why**?
- What has this community already **built for itself**?

> Synthesis doesn't just organize your data. It can **break your frame**.

What Synthesis Revealed

- **Trust**: "I access a system that doesn't want me in it and nothing changes"
- **Safety**: "You think I'm putting my real address on a government form?"
- **Deliberate choice**: Non-voters have specific reasons. This isn't apathy.
- **Community self-reliance**: Mutual aid, community fridges, legal networks. "We take care of us."
- **Exhaustion**: "I did everything right in 2020... I'm tired."

The problem isn't access. It's the **relationship between this community and formal institutions**.

Your Turn

Same method. Your data.

Your Turn

Your data will be harder because you're invested in it. That investment will make you want to skip to conclusions.

> Does your data confirm your assumptions, or does it tell a **different story**?

Team Synthesis Protocol

Breakout rooms by team.

1. Each person posts their raw observations on the team whiteboard. **No narrating. Silent.** (5 min)
2. Everyone reads everyone else's observations. **Silent.** (3 min)
3. One person starts clustering. Others can **only ask questions**, not move stickies. Rotate after 4 min.
4. **Name three patterns.** Write one sentence for each.
5. **Identify one thing that doesn't fit** any pattern. Discuss what it might mean.

20 minutes

Stress Test Your Causal Loop

You built it before you synthesized. Does it still hold?

Causal Loop Stress Test

Pull up your causal loop map (the one you submitted today).

Look at it through the lens of what you just synthesized.

- **What holds up?** Which loops does your research data actually support?
- **What's missing?** Is there a dynamic your data revealed that isn't on the map?
- **What did you assume?** Point to a loop. Is it based on evidence or assumption?
- **What needs to change?** Mark it. You don't have to fix it now. Name it.

15 minutes

Assignment Changes

A few things are shifting based on where we are in the course:

What	Old	New	Why
Problem Definition (A05)	Due Apr 4	**Due Apr 1**	So I can review and give feedback before Session 5
Final Presentation (A06)	Session 5 (Apr 4)	**Session 6 (Apr 9)**	You'll run an experiment between S5 and S6, then present what you learned
Reflection Essay (A08)	Due Apr 9	**Cut**	The experiment presentation replaces it

What's Due

Problem Definition Document — Wednesday, April 1

- **Bounded, evidence-based problem statement**
- **Revised causal loop map** with what changed after tonight and why
- I'll review and give feedback **before Session 5**

Write it while the thinking is fresh.

What's Ahead

Session 5 (Sat Apr 4, in-person): You come in with a defined problem. We ideate, stress test, and design experiments.

Session 6 (Thu Apr 9, online): You present what you tested and what you learned.

Find the Duct Tape: Keep collecting.